Ossetia. In June, Pliev came to the attention not only of his former commander and supporter, Marshal Malinovsky, but of the entire Communist Party Presidium. That month workers in the industrial city of Novocherkassk in the center of the Don Cossack region of southern Russia went on strike to protest an increase in the prices of meat and butter. Khrushchev's government, struggling to make ends meet in the midst of a food crisis caused by bad weather and mismanagement of the agricultural sector, had resorted to that measure. The workers besieged the local party headquarters, driving out the high-level delegation sent to Novocherkassk by Khrushchev himself: among its members was Anastas Mikoyan.

Frol Kozlov, a secretary of the Central Committee and Khrushchev's second in command, ordered not only KGB and police personnel but also soldiers into the streets. Pliev in turn ordered his tanks, armed with live ammunition, to move into the city. The tanks were never used against the rebels, but Interior Ministry troops under Pliev's operational command opened fire on the protesters, killing at least twenty-four and wounding eighty-seven. The revolt was suppressed. Its surviving leaders and activists were put on trial: of those, seven were sentenced to death and shot.[12]

What happened in Novocherkassk on June 2, as well as Pliev's participation in the events, remained a top state secret until the last days of the USSR. But the Russian dissident writer Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn described the Novocherkassk events in his 1968 documentary novel. According to Solzhenitsyn, Pliev, an Ossetian by birth, used non-Russian soldiers to shoot at the Russian protesters, and then, once the shooting was over, replaced them with ethnic Russians to take the blame for what had happened. The debate on Pliev's role in suppressing the Novocherkassk uprising continues to this day. Some suggest that he exercised caution and acted under duress, while others indicate that only the refusal of his subordinates to use live ammunition prevented even greater bloodshed. Whatever the truth of the matter, Pliev's role in suppressing the revolt clearly pleased the higher-ups, and he gained new political capital in the Kremlin. Not only Malinovsky but also Khrushchev now knew that they could count on the general.[13]

Pliev was summoned to Moscow on July 4 in the middle of maneuvers that he was conducting in his district and ordered to take command of the